

Some people think that philosophy is of no relevance to everyday concerns.

I hope that our class has disabused you of this notion. However, in this last class, I would like to turn the tools of philosophical analysis on two questions of great current concern.

Was the College Football Playoff
committee's decision to exclude
Notre Dame competent, or
incompetent?

Was the College Football Playoff committee's decision to exclude Notre Dame honest, or corrupt?

Logically that there are four exclusive and exhaustive possibilities.

The decision
was
competent
and honest.

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.

Here is an argument against the first possibility.

1. If the committee's decision was competent and honest, then the committee did not rely on absurd principles in making its decision.
2. The committee relied on absurd principles in making its decision.

C. The committee's decision was not competent and honest. (1,2)

The argument is valid, and the first premise is obvious. It remains therefore to demonstrate the second premise.

One may rely on various principles in constructing rankings of this kind, and the appropriate principles will of course depend on the ranking. Nonetheless we can isolate one general kind of principle which one might use, which I will call a **magic touching rule**.

A magic touching rule is a rule which says that when two of the ranked items are 'touching' — i.e., adjacent in the rankings — then we look to a special extra condition — this is the magic part — to see whether the two touching items in the ranking should have their spots flipped.

Magic touching rule

If two teams in the ranking are touching and played head to head and the lower ranked team defeated the higher ranked team then the teams' rankings are flipped.

The committee employs a rule of this kind.

The committee's task is to rank the country's football teams from best to worst, based on their performance. This is a general kind of task. One might also seek to similarly rank the best universities, or best philosophy departments, or best cars, or whatever.

would like to turn the topic of philosophical analysis into questions of great



current concern.

hope that our class has disabled you of this notion. However, in this last class, I

Was the College Football Playoff
committee's decision to exclude
Notre Dame competent, or
incompetent?

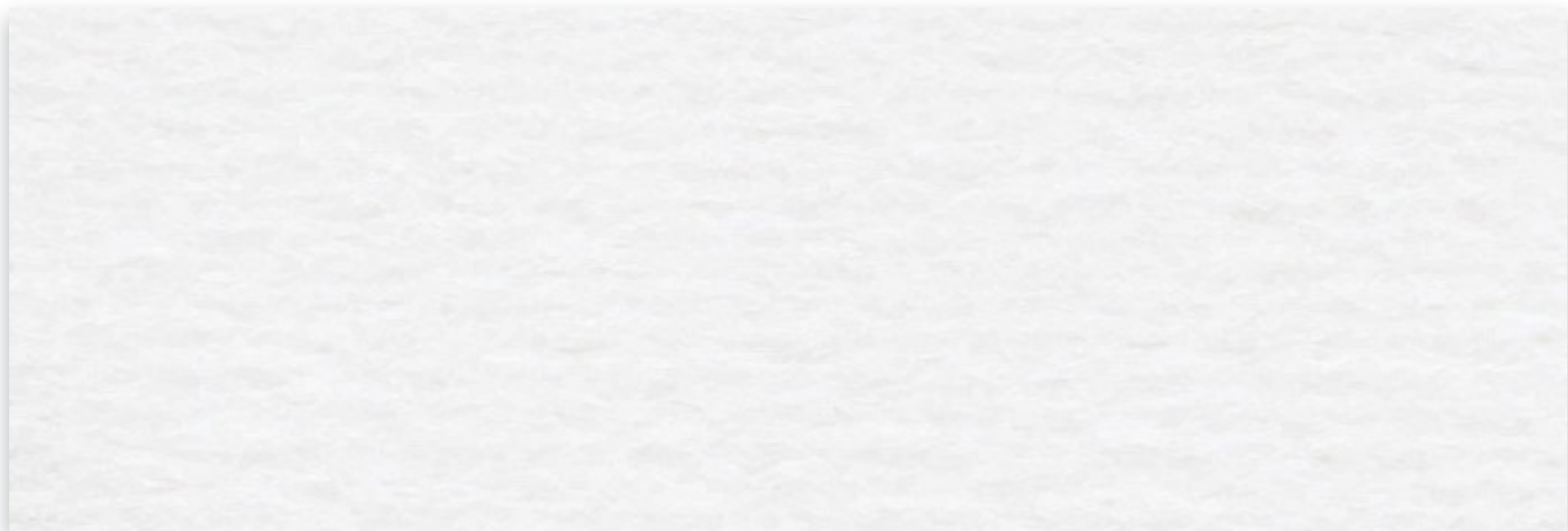
Was the College Football Playoff
committee's decision to exclude
Notre Dame honest, or corrupt?

The decision
was
competent
and honest.

The decision
was
competent
and corrupt.

The decision
was
incompetent
and honest.

The decision
was
incompetent
and corrupt.



absurd principles in making its decision.



2. The committee relied on absurd principles in

making its decision.

1. If the committee's decision was competent and

honest.(1,2)

honest, then they committed not rely on

The committee's decision was not competent and

remains therefore to demonstrate the second premise.

The argument is valid, and the first premise is obvious. It

The committee's task is to rank the country's football teams

the best universities, or best philosophy departments, or best

cars, or whatever.

general kind of task. One might also seek to similarly rank

from best to worst, based on their performance. This is a

of this kind, and the appropriate principles will of course

call it magic touch nothing rule.

One may rely on various principles in constructing rankings

dependent on the ranking. Nonetheless we can isolate one

general kind of principle which one might use, which will

A magical thinking rule is a rule which says that when two of

rankings — then we look to a special extra condition — this

is the magic part — to see whether the two touching items

in the rankings should have their spots flipped.

the ranked items are 'touching' i.e., adjacent in the



